Autobiography of a Yogi

Autobiography of a Yogi as a title for a book sounded strange indeed to my Indian ears—for it is not traditional for a yogī in India to speak of himself as such, nor does a spiritual man call himself by the highest title "Paramhansa," which is reserved for only those rare souls who have attained their liberation from the bondage of earthly life and activity and live in complete equanimity of mind *(samādhi).* (Not even Swami Vivekananda called himself or was ever referred to as "Paramhansa.") I draw the attention of the reader to these technical inaccuracies, because in spiritual matters they are not only misleading to the public but actually harmful to the spiritual aspirant himself.

Autobiography of a Yogi is an astonishing book and was probably written from a combination of motives, from the legitimate one of self-advertisement to the noble one of acquainting a foreign reader with the supernatural power of the spiritual forces over the physical world, believed to have been possessed by the yogīs in India. But, unfortunately, this autobiography focuses the attention of the reader on just those aspects of spiritual life and yoga which for ages have been regarded as hindrances in the path of a yogī's relization of God. Other persons, therefore, who claim to know India and respect her for her spiritual achievements in the past and the present, may be forgiven if they do not regard God-realization and yoga as Swami Yogananda does.

To review specifically the contents of this autobiography of forty-eight chapters would be only a repetition. The reader is merely led from chapter to chapter in a narrative of miraculous occurrences, the majority of which happen to the author himself, or to which the author was witness. If we assume them all to be authentic, they produce an impression that the essence of a spiritual or divine life has centered around supernatural powers and their exercise—which in some cases call upon God to satisfy